What are Political Parties?

Political parties, which are voluntary associations of individuals with broad ideological identity who agree on some policies, formulate an agenda and programme for the society. Political parties seek to implement their policies by winning people's support through election. Parties vary in size and in the ways they organize themselves as well as in their policies.

Any political party has three basic components

- ❖ the leader
- ❖ the active members
- ❖ the followers

Importance of political parties

Political parties are the backbone of democracy. Parties are not part of the formal arrangement of a government but they are essential elements to form the government. They formulate public opinion. They serve as intermediaries between the citizen and the policy makers.

A party is recognized if

- ❖ it has been engaged in political activity for five years.
- ❖ its candidates secure at least six percent of total votes in the last general election.

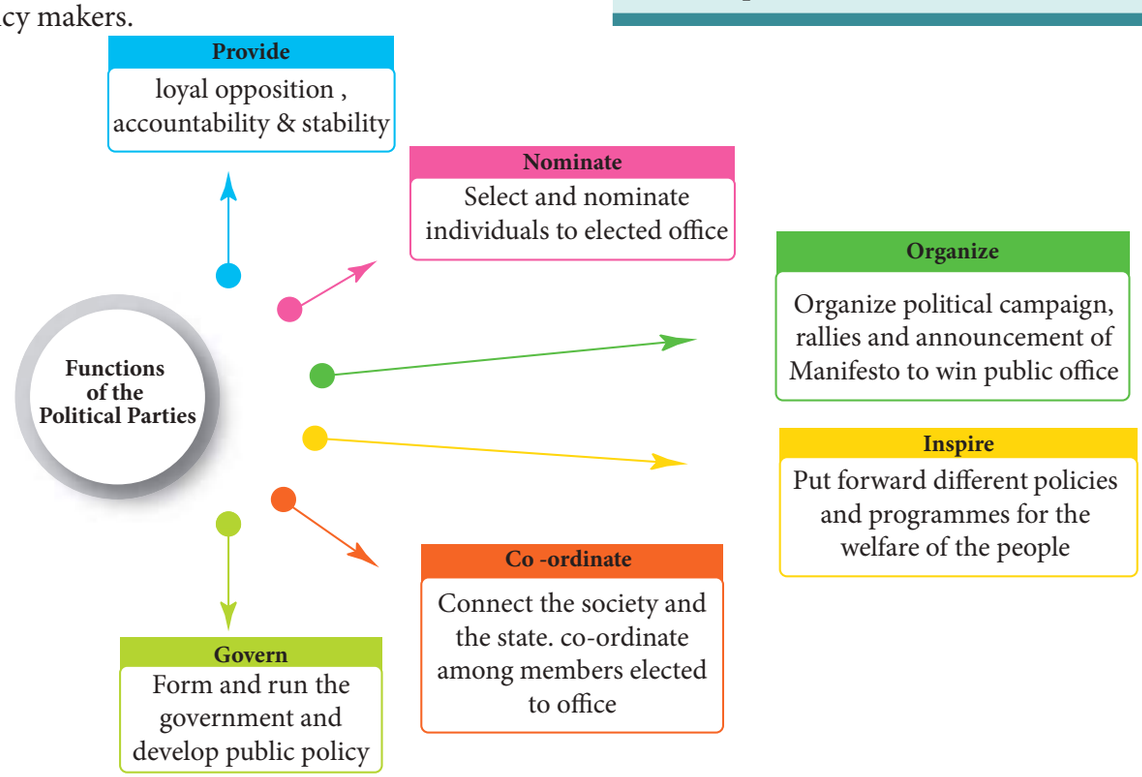
Characteristics of Political Parties

Political parties

- ❖ consists of a group of persons with common goals and shared values.
- ❖ have its own ideology and programme.
- ❖ capture power only by constitutional means.
- ❖ endeavour to promote the national interest and national welfare.

Party '*manifesto*'

During the campaign before election, the candidates announce the programmes and policies that their party will undertake if voted to power.



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